

Storytelling in Contemporary Choreography

- A lecture-demonstration
- Jean Mullen, Ceili Mor Academy of Dance
- Chennai Arts Festival Conference, December 2026

Speaker note: Open in silence. Let the body arrive before the words. I greet them, then I dance eight counts before I say anything.

The foot speaks first

- Story does not begin in the program note
- It begins in weight, rhythm, and breath
- A treble is a sentence before it is a step

Speaker note: Demonstrate a single hard-shoe treble. Ask them what they heard, not what they saw. Margaret's note: open with the body, not the theory.

Two traditions, one room

- Munster footwork: down into the floor, grounded
- Contemporary line: breath, spill, suspension
- Not translation. Conversation.

Speaker note: Two dancers, one of each vocabulary, same phrase. Let the audience see them answer each other.

Five Elements as a case study

- Earth, water, fire, air, ether
- Each element is a narrative problem, not a theme
- How rhythm carries meaning across the five movements

Speaker note: Short clips or live fragments from Earth and Fire. Keep it about the storytelling choice, not the spectacle.

What the audience completes

- The dance offers, the watcher finishes
- Do not over-explain. Trust them to rise
- Projection supports the story, it does not tell it

Speaker note: Close on this. The audience can rise to the material. End with one held image and let it sit before questions.